

# WASHINGTON OWNER-BUILDER PERMIT KIT

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Keep the exemption · File the permits · Pass the inspections

Project Address: \_\_\_\_\_

County: \_\_\_\_\_

City / Town: \_\_\_\_\_

Owner-Builder: \_\_\_\_\_

Permit Application Date: \_\_\_\_\_

Every Washington statute, rule, and threshold in this kit  
is cited on the page it appears on — verified August 2026.

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First Edition — 2026

# How to Use This Kit

Five working documents that take a Washington owner-builder from "am I allowed to do this?" to a final inspection.

Washington gives you a genuinely good deal. The building code is statewide and mandatory — *"there shall be in effect in all counties and cities the state building code"* — so there is no county where the rules are a mystery, and none where they simply do not apply. There is no general contractor license to qualify for, only a registration you are exempt from on your own property. And a complete permit application **locks in the rules on the day you file it**.

What catches owner-builders here is not difficulty, it is **geography of authority**: the permits for one house come from more than one agency. Your building permit comes from a city or county. Your **electrical** permit usually comes from the State — Labor & Industries — because the residential code hands electrical work to a different rule book entirely: *"Electrical Code is regulated by chapter 296-46B WAC or Electrical Code as adopted by the local jurisdiction."* Septic and wells come from a third office again. This kit separates them so you know which counter you are standing at.

*RCW 19.27.031(1); WAC 51-51-003, the rule adopting the 2021 International Residential Code for Washington. Both read at [app.leg.wa.gov](http://app.leg.wa.gov), August 2026.*

## WHAT IS IN THE KIT

### The five documents

|             | Document                            | What it does for you                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>WA.1</b> | Owner-Builder Exemption Walkthrough | Which exemption you are actually using, what takes it away, and the separate rules for doing your own electrical and plumbing. <b>Read this first.</b> |
| <b>WA.2</b> | Permit Application Checklist        | What to gather and verify before you file — water, septic, critical areas, the energy code paperwork, and the clocks the State puts on your reviewer.  |
| <b>WA.3</b> | Inspection Sequence                 | The order inspections happen in, which agency calls each one, the three tests you must pass, and fields for dates and results.                         |
| <b>WA.4</b> | Where to File Directory             | Every office you will deal with, how to find yours, and a page to write down what you confirmed.                                                       |
| <b>WA.5</b> | Forms & Documents Index             | Each document you will meet: what it is, when, and from where.                                                                                         |

## HOW TO USE IT

- **Start with WA.1.** If you do not qualify for the exemption, nothing else in the kit matters yet.
- **Fill in WA.4 before you need it.** Washington sends you to more counters than most states; an hour spent finding them early saves a week of chasing later.
- **Work WA.2 with a pen** and do not file until the boxes are checked. In Washington a *complete* application is worth more than an early one — completeness is what starts your reviewer's clock and what freezes the rules in your favor.
- **Keep WA.3 on the job** and record every inspection date and result as it happens — including the ones you call to a different agency.

### How these facts were checked — and what this is not

Every Washington claim here was read against its primary source — the RCW and WAC text at [app.leg.wa.gov](http://app.leg.wa.gov), and the responsible agency's own pages — in August 2026, and is cited where it appears. Where the answer is local, the kit says so and gives you the verification step instead of guessing. This is a process reference, not legal advice, and it does not replace your building department or the State Building Code. Washington runs a three-year code cycle and amends between cycles — confirm anything you rely on.